

The Living Fossils

A Fantasy Play

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In Loving Memory of

Carly Christine Glynn

CAST OF CHARACTERS

CÁT LÝ TRẦN (32) is a Vietnamese native living in Haiphong. A physician by trade and storyteller by nature. Protective and deeply connected to ancestral memory. She is a living fossil herself, bridging her studies in Maine and life in Vietnam.

KOOKY is a wise horseshoe crab (Cát may double or voice her).

ACADIA NOBLE TRẦN (8/15) is Cát's daughter. A genius 7th grader. She is skeptical and prefers her phone to folklore. She views the world through a scientific lens but possesses a curiosity about her heritage. Born in Maine, she grew up in Haiphong with her mom. She grows up to be the world's youngest biochemist.

*Vendors, ancestors, horseshoe crabs, and other ensembles may be brought to life through puppetry

SETTINGS

Year: 2034 (Act I), 2042 (Act II)

Haiphong, Vietnam: Home, Pho Restaurant; Hanoi, Vietnam

Cát Bà Archipelago: The Sea, Fossil Island, Monkey Island

Maine: Laboratory

NOTES

/ - interruptions or interjections

Vietnamese is spoken. Long dialogue in *italics* is spoken in Viet with English translations projected as subtitles on a scrim. These subtitles are not always literal. They can be subtext.

Puppetry: Horseshoe crabs (16-inch adult and 4-inch juvenile).

Lighting: When horseshoe crabs get hurt or bite, the lighting effects should emphasize the bioluminescence of the crab's blue blood, signaling a shift from natural to supernatural.

Scrim: Shadow puppetry, sea imagery, ancestry, projections, etc.

SYNOPSIS

A young biochemist must face her wild past and challenge her scientific future when she teams up with a Vietnamese horseshoe crab to find her mother, who was lost at sea near Fossil Island.

UONG NUỐC

OCEAN FLOOR BY VIETNAM

Waves crash, gulls scream off the coast of Vietnam. A scrim hangs.

A quote projects: "UONG NUỐC NHO NGUON." ("WHEN DRINKING WATER, REMEMBER THE SOURCE.")

CÁT LÝ TRAN and her four-year-old daughter ACADIA look in the water. In it, a shadowy mother-daughter pair of HORSESHOE CRABS swim together through puppetry.

Dialogue in *italics* is spoken in Vietnamese with English subtitles projected on the scrim.

CÁT

(in Vietnamese)

The shoreline feels safe, but the open sea knows truth.

ACADIA

No souls lost on my watch. Splash!

CÁT

Gentle currents change nothing. The powerful crashes of waves are what reshapes sand.

ACADIA

Does it make a loud noise?

CÁT

Very loud. A kinetic clash that shakes us creatures awake.

ACADIA

We are creatures? Like monsters? With sharp claws? Hard shells?

CÁT

We're armored for a reason, little one. The world has sharp teeth.

The mother puppet lifts her young on her shell, following a current. The lighting shifts to a murky green as they enter a shallow bay.

CÁT (CONT'D)

*A calm bay must break its own shoreline to stay
an open sea.*

ACADIA

Change won't wait for us?

Am aggressive and mechanical roar
of a boat motor cuts through.

CÁT

(in English)

Change says... Out with the old...

A boat's shadow engulfs all. The
mother looks up in pure terror.

A massive, heavy iron ANCHOR
drops, plunging towards her baby.

CÁT (CONT'D)

...In with the-

ACADIA

New!

The sand obscures everything.

SCENE 1

A HOME IN HAIPHONG, VIETNAM, 2034

Lights up in a Vietnamese bedroom.
It's 2034, so a blend of modern
and traditional. Outside the
window, a distant billboard
advertises two horseshoe crabs for
an aquarium. Graphics read "Hóa
Thạch Sùng" and "Luc Nay 2034."

Eight-year-old Acadia takes a
photo of the billboard on a phone.

ACADIA

New word of the day. Tac-hi-

CÁT (O.S.)

(in Vietnamese, subtitled)

Trời ơi, con nho này!

(Oh goodness, this girl!)

Cát, wearing a physician's coat,
enters. She cascades "love" that
only a Vietnamese mom would give.

ACADIA

Oh my goodness, today / is

CÁT

/ *Troi đất oi, cái phòng nhu heo, thôi quá trời!*
(Oh my god, you live like a pig, it stinks
to high heaven!)

SUBTITLE: Oh god, you smell like
heaven!

ACADIA

Me (Mom). It's MY day today, okay? We ain't
speaking none of that.

CÁT

Thức dậy thì ôm PHONE!
(You wake up hugging that phone!)

SUBTITLE: Please waste your life
on your phone!

ACADIA

It's YOUR phone! For my special day, we're
speaking ALIEN.

CÁT

(In English)

Cadi (K D) Noble... Stubborn. *Ngang nhu cua.*
(Stubborn as a crab.)
You're speaking my second language. Well...
Nhìn gì?

(What are you looking at?)

Saddle up! Put on your shoes!

ACADIA

Love you!

Acadia wears a naval school uniform
and plays with her red neckerchief.

A motorcycle revs loudly outside.

CÁT (O.S.)

Cadi! ACADIA NOBLE TRAN!!!

Acadia straps her VIET LEAF HAT
(nón lá) to her back and runs out.

The house becomes the vibrant
coastal HAIPHONG. Modern signage
clashes with folksy stalls.
Pedestrians may crowd the streets
with sugarcanes and bún cha bowls.

Acadia sits behind Cát on a
motorcycle, with their leaf hats.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Keep playing with my neckerchief, dear. It's stretching its limits.

ACADIA

Whatever floats your boat. Motorcycle today?

CÁT

We're running errands in style!

They drive around until they stop
by a ceramic stall.

Cát purchases a bowl.

ACADIA

A bowl? Another cái bát? I got one for each day
of the week already.

CÁT

Now you have eight.

ACADIA

And when I'm old like you, I'll have one for
everyday of the month.

CÁT

Ăn đòn không, muôn ăn đòn không?!

(Want a beating? Are you asking for one?!)

SUBTITLE: I love you so much, it
hurts.

Acadia shows Cát the billboard
photo on her phone.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Tachypleus gigas. Horseshoe crab in Latin. But
"gigas"? No way they get that huge.

ACADIA

They get fifty centimeters big, *Me* ("Mom")!

CÁT

Ha! I've baked longer baguettes. "*Gigas*." Ah
since you got my phone, book our reservation!

ACADIA

Why not you?

CÁT

I got to stop *reserving* all the joys of
reserving for myself!

ACADIA

Please dial back the puns, mom.

CÁT

You actually need to *dial*.

Acadia rolls her eyes and dials.

ACADIA

8...

They park by a restaurant and find a table.

SCENE 2

PHO RESTAURANT IN HAIPHONG, VIETNAM

A small restaurant near the harbor. Cát and Acadia sit at a table. Acadia's bowl of PHO is untouched. Empty plates of mollusk shells are stacked on Cát's side.

Cát holds up a placemat featuring zodiac animals for a selfie with a grumpy Acadia.

CÁT

(Looking at her phone)

Birthday number 8. Sinh nhật của, Cadi Noble.

On the scrim, we can see Cát scroll through past photos. All at the same table, taken yearly with Cát holding placemats with animals of the year descending from 2034 to 2027 (when Acadia was one). The 2027 photo shows them with an Indonesian man in a U.S. Coast Guard shirt. Le khai trương / Grand opening ribbons hang around.

Cát sighs as anguish clouds her.

ACADIA

Nhìn gì, mẹ?

(What are you looking at, mom?)

CÁT

Nothing. You still got so much in your bowl.

ACADIA

I'm not hungry.

CÁT

Empty stomach, empty head.

ACADIA

And you have a big belly.

Cát looks insulted.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

So *big brained*.

Cát points her chopsticks at the contents of the pho bowl: slices of beef, rice noodles, and herbs.

CÁT

Fine. If it gets you to eat, I'll show you what's been on my mind.

She points at a slice of beef.

CÁT (CONT'D)

There are 367 islands...

She points to one large piece.

CÁT (CONT'D)

...off the coast of Vietnam...

She dramatically twirls noodles between the beefy "islands."

CÁT (CONT'D)

...and a whirlpool that hides...

She uses a spoon to raise a bone fragment and tries to shove it into Acadia's mouth.

CÁT (CONT'D)

...our ancestral island.

ACADIA

Ew! Mom! That's a bone—

Cát holds the bone up to the light. On the scrim, a horseshoe crab-shaped island appears.

CÁT

Exactly. The bone is Fossil Island. A spiritual place where we can reconnect with those who've *molted* away. They live among horseshoe spirits.

Shadow puppets of glowing
horseshoe crabs appear, their
tails flicking in a dance.

ACADIA

Horseshoe crabs are invertebrates.

CÁT

I never said they had bones. Their life force
is actually in their blue blood. It remembers
anything the sea washes away. It heals wounds.

ACADIA

What if you lose an arm? Does it grow back?

CÁT

Wow. Sick sense of humor. But such power makes
them a target. We keep our island secret from
outsiders who want to exploit the blood. This
island goes deeper than bones. It's our souls.
Me, my mom, her mom... we were all born there.

ACADIA

And I was born on mainland...

The puppetry shows a woman and man
in a naval uniform holding a baby.

CÁT

Maine, where I met your father. We were
opposites. Science and spirit, east and west,
the law said we couldn't be together, but there
was Relic Island... it didn't care about laws.
It only cared about the source of water.

But back in Maine-land... We thought having you
could keep us together. Birthright didn't work.

MILITANT PUPPETS push puppet Cát,
her baby, and other puppets onto a
boat to Vietnam. They are the
inverse Vietnamese boat people.

CÁT (CONT'D)

I became the only option for you. And now
you're here.

I'll bring you the whole world. I'll bring you
algae. I'll bring you mollusk shells. I'll
bring you clams. I'll bring you fishes-CRABS!
I'll bring you everything but...

ACADIA & CÁT

...peace...

They giggle together.

ACADIA

You're why I'm no horse girl like other kids.

Acadia sees a tank of seahorses in the scrim. She's mesmerised.

CÁT

You're more of a seahorse girl.

ACADIA

They're cooler in water than land. They live for up to five years.

CÁT

And like you, you're ahead in schooling by five years. Well, the tide is turning. We have to go now if we want to reach Fossil Island.

They look towards the harbor. Cát puts Acadia's pho in a container.

Lights fade as the table and chairs pull away, and the hull of the VAST sailboat is pushed in.

SCENE 3

HAIPHONG PORT - CÁT BÀ ARCHIPELAGO

Waves crash as boat engines rev.

Cát and Acadia make their way to a port. They enter the VAST sailboat and set off to the archipelago.

CÁT

Today is the gift of a lifetime! You're going to reconnect with your ancestors!

Acadia points at a projected lush green cliff on the scrim.

ACADIA

On that island?!

CÁT

No, dear... Not Monkey Island...

ACADIA

Oo oo ah ah! My classmates go to Monkey Island for their birthdays! They get to feed the monkeys and eat ice cream.

CÁT

Cause they're a bunch of monkeys.

ACADIA

And you're a fossil.

CÁT

Don't make me turn this boat around!

A white fog rolls over the water.

ACADIA

You know where we're going? Every island looks the same. Just rocks and trees, more rocks.

CÁT

My parents named me after the archipelago. The first thing I ever felt was its sand. I know this area more than myself. Remember this route as one day, you'll have to find it without me.

Acadia pulls out the phone.

ACADIA

Phone, tell me where Fossil Island is!

PHONE (V.O.)

No signal here.

CÁT

You kids cannot survive without technology. You want the world in your pocket, but you won't look at it when it's right in front of you.

ACADIA

Beats being a hermit.

CÁT

I never quite understood that metaphor. Hermit crabs are the most open to change.

ACADIA

No way.

CÁT

Hermit crabs are like us. They move to new homes, they immigrate, they're never satisfied.

If you won't remember the way, at least, don't downplay my story.

In a tide pool, where the sea and shore whisper secrets to each other, lived a shy hermit crab named *Paguroidea*.

ACADIA

Mom, can you stop being so nerdy?

CÁT

What's your favorite *Animal Crossing* character?

ACADIA

Blathers! He's the best!

CÁT

Not Tom Nook? Whatever.

Their name's *Blathers* who grew too big for their shell. It was like a hoodie that became too small! They needed a new home, one that may let them stretch out and grow bigger.

At the same time, a human named Nook felt the same way about their house. It was a nice house, but it felt old and didn't fit who Nook was anymore. The house felt like a big boat stuck on the land.

Encouraged by the high tide, Nook and Blathers started looking for new homes. It was scary!

Blathers searched 'til they found a shiny, smooth shell. They left a tight shell behind and slipped into the new one. It wasn't perfect yet, but they knew they could make it home.

Nook also moved their boxes into a new house. They felt happy and a little sad to leave the old one. As they drove away, they looked back at the empty house, then focused on the new adventure ahead.

They learned a home isn't just wood or a shell but a place where you can become who you're meant to be!

ACADIA

And all these other islands are like shells nobody wanted.

Cát shifts the sail.

SCENE 4

FOSSIL ISLAND

The mist parts. Horseshoe-shaped cliffs appear. It's ominous and ancient.

CÁT

But not ours... We have arrived at Fossil
Island! Happy birthday, Cadi Noble...

Cát drops the ANCHOR over the
side. A sickening CRUNCH echoes.
Blue light swirls around the boat.

ACADIA

Me ("Mom")! That water is super duper blue.
More pretty than the ocean.

CÁT

(Staring at the blue blood in shame)
To set eyes on our sacred island is a great
honor. To set foot on its shores needs a
special blessing.

ACADIA

I wanna play on the beach! It's my birthday!

CÁT

Not for me to decide. That's your ancestors'.

ACADIA

Hey ancestors! Can I play on your beach?!

CÁT

The spirits are upset, Cadi. Look at the water.
They don't want us here. Not yet.

ACADIA

I don't care what dead people think!

CÁT

No one truly dies if we continue to care!

ACADIA

Still don't care!

CÁT (CONT'D)

Don't speak about them in
that way.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Fine! I'll play nice if I see them!

CÁT

You're not ready. It was a mistake / bringing

Acadia ejects the ring of keys in
the cabin, turning the motor off.

ACADIA

/ Leaving is the mistake! You can't make me go!
I have the keys!

CÁT

ACADIA NOBLE TRAN. HAND ME THE KEYS!

ACADIA

Can we grab coconuts first?

CÁT

You still need to finish the pho and cake.

Cát holds up the pho container.
She also gets a box with Acadia's
birthday cake. She opens it.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Trust me, eight cakes goes by real quick. The
spirits will welcome you as the woman you're
meant to be once you listen. Now, make a wish.

Acadia blows out an imaginary
candle.

ACADIA

I wish to meet my ancestors. NOW.

CÁT

That's sweet of you to say.

ACADIA

Not too sweet!

CÁT

You're speaking Viet.

ACADIA

Promise me you'll be here with me.

CÁT

When the time comes. Promise.

Cát reaches over the side to pull
the anchor rope. A sharp wet SNAP.

CÁT (CONT'D)

OW! *Nước can tay!*
(The water bit me!)

YOUNG ACADIA

ME (Viet: "Mom")?!

Cát pulls up her bleeding wrist.

Acadia screams and dives towards
the floor, grabbing the juvenile
horseshoe crab in the water.

CÁT

Let her go!

On the scrim, the ancestral
memories project: ancient warriors
clashing, French soldiers
marching, rice farmers weeping.

CÁT (CONT'D)

We don't need the powers that be to reincarnate
you into a plankton!

Acadia, shocked by the fury in her
mother's tone, reluctantly lets
the horseshoe crab go. She gets
back on the boat.

ACADIA

Where's first aid?

CÁT

In the compartment, dear.

Acadia goes to the locked
compartment and feels her pockets.
THE KEYS ARE MISSING.

ACADIA

The keys are gone!

CÁT

Those who steal can never keep.

ACADIA

Mom?!

CÁT

(Clutching her bleeding hand)

It must have fallen in the bay...

Acadia dips her face into the
water to look. She hears an
ANCESTRAL CACOPHONY. She freaks
out and almost drowns.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Breathe, Acadia. I can't lose you, too.

Forget the keys. We don't need the motor. We
must go manual. We've got two hands to sail. I
got my second best hand to point. *Nho nguon.*

Cát takes Acadia's red neckerchief
and wraps it on her bloody wrist.

ACADIA

Let's go home.

As the boat sails away slower than ever, the crab resurfaces with a ring of KEYS ON HER RAISED TAIL.

Acadia stares on in shock as the creature swims away.

The red sail rips. The mast tilts. The deafening blow of the typhoon.

Black out.

SCENE 5

THE SAILBOAT IN THE SEA

Total darkness, save for the glow of lightning. The sea is a chaotic void, the mast now lying broken on the floor. Rain endlessly falls.

Acadia crawls through the wreck, soaking wet. Cát slumps against a mast, her leaf hat covering her face. Her breathing is shallow.

ACADIA

It's way past my bedtime. Where to, Mom?

Cát raises her rashy arm with tremors. Drool escapes her mouth.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Mom! Like you always said, drink enough water!

Acadia scrabbles towards the water jugs, then sees they are empty. She finds the plastic container of pho and brings it to Cát's lips.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Pho juice will do!

CÁT

Broth...?

ACADIA (CONT'D)

It's been forever. You sure we're going the right way? I can't see the stars.

CÁT

Use your ears, child.

THUNDER shakes everything.

Cát pukes. Acadia notices the
rashes blooming on Cát's arm.

ACADIA

Please don't get scurvy, mom.

Acadia gets pho for Cát and twirls
its noodles with chopsticks.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Eat. Please.

Acadia looks out to see a ship-
eating whirlpool.

CÁT

Who are you asking?

Cát nabs Acadia's chopstick with
noodles then drops it. The noodles
form a swirl design on the floor.

CÁT (CONT'D)

Told you to remember the whirlpool, silly noodl-

ACADIA

You didn't tell me it was THAT big!

CÁT

The big things never get me. So it'll be the
small things that'll do.

ACADIA

That doesn't make sense!

CÁT

Whirlpool's nothing. I've sailed mere meters by
it. But I can't walk, swim, sail one more meter-

ACADIA

You'll feel better. We need to return to shore.

CÁT

It's unlike the cold. Absolute zero, love.

ACADIA

But you're no zero. You have friends. You're a
hospital doctor!

CÁT

I don't think my hospital have much to work
with even if we get there.

ACADIA

They need you! I need you!

Cát unwraps the cloth from her wrist and wraps it around Acadia's collar. Her blood is now bluish.

CÁT

Cadi needs an armor more than mom.

ACADIA

Me (Viet: Mom), no!

CÁT

Wherever you go, I'll bring you the whole world. I'll bring you algae. I'll bring you mollusk shells. I'll bring you clams. I'll bring you fishes, CRABS! I'll bring you everything but...

ACADIA & CÁT

...peace...

Cát rests. Acadia goes to the helm and steers away from the whirlpool.

ACADIA

No souls lost on my watch!

Another mast gives way. Acadia dodges it and dives into the sea. The lights cut to a deep blue.

Silence. Then the deep-sea sound of Coelacanths replaces the storm.

Acadia bursts out the water, gasping for air and clinging to debris. She watches the boat be pulled towards a whirlpool.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Me (Viet: "Mom")!

Cát calmly looks up. She raises her injured arm. The blue glow from the seafloor swallows her.

CÁT

Uong nước nhỏ nguồn.

Before vanishing in the whirlpool, the sailboat illuminates the shape of a horseshoe crab.

Acadia watches in horror.

ACADIA

It's all your fault! I hate you, horseshoe! I
will end you! Every single one of you!

The thunder fades into gulls.

Lights rise onto a calm beach.

SCENE 6

MONKEY ISLAND

Acadia lies on the beach.

Through puppetry, golden-headed
langur monkeys enter and curiously
loom over Acadia. They coo.

The waterlogged phone miraculously
flickers to life nearby.

PHONE

(in Vietnamese; subtitled)

*That's the call of a Trachypithecus
poliocephalus, or Cát...*

Acadia sobs hearing her mom's name.

PHONE (CONT'D)

*...Bà langur, the rarest primates in the world
with a population of less than 100 individuals.*

Acadia sits up to meet the langurs
at their level.

ACADIA

Your family is gone, too?

The langurs coo, happy the crying
stopped. They hand her the phone.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Now you have signal... Maybe not of all my
family is gone...

The PHONE beeps, then a muffled
voice of a man is heard as Acadia
holds the phone to her ear. Acadia
plays with her red neckerchief.

END OF UONG NUỐC

NHO NGUON

OCEAN FLOOR BY VIETNAM

Waves crash, gulls scream off the coast of Vietnam. A scrim hangs.

A quote projects: "WHEN DRINKING WATER, REMEMBER THE SOURCE."
("UONG NUOC NHO NGUON.")

In the water, an adult HORSESHOE CRAB swims alone.

CÁT

The shoreline feels safe, but the open sea knows truth.

ACADIA

No souls lost on my watch. Splash!

CÁT

Gentle currents change nothing. The powerful crashes of waves are what reshapes sand.

ACADIA

Does it make a loud noise?

CÁT

Very loud. A kinetic clash that shakes us creatures awake.

ACADIA

We are creatures? Like monsters? With sharp claws? Hard shells?

CÁT

We're armored for a reason, little one. The world has sharp teeth.

CÁT (CONT'D)

A calm bay must break its own shoreline to stay an open sea.

ACADIA

Change won't wait for us?

CÁT

(in English)

Change says... Out with the old...

CÁT (CONT'D)

...In with the-

ACADIA

New!

A NET catches the horseshoe crab and places them in a container.

SCENE 1

A LAB IN MAINE, 2042

Lights up on a state-of-the-art biochemical lab in 2042. The walls feature a poster about the medical characteristics of horseshoe crabs, as well as diplomas and articles. Multiple water tanks containing inactive horseshoe crabs are scattered around the room, with a specific container positioned on a lab station.

Separately, 15-year-old Acadia is seated, neglecting her pho to grab a bone fragment from the broth.

ACADIA

It all happened so fast once I got to Maine. I lived with my dad, Morgan Noble, always absent on his Coast Guard missions. Time flew by as I studied hard, skipped grades, won national science awards, and got scholarships. I graduated high school as valedictorian at age 10. Then it was off to Bowdoin College for medicine, and I became a biochemist by 13.

Life's weird. I'm the kid too short for the ride, a college student who needs parental consent, and the youngest in all friend groups.

Mom said I'd never be a horse girl like the other kids. And she's still right. Instead, I am an Atlantic horseshoe crab's worst nightmare. I drew their blue blood in the lab, determined to be the scientist who saved the world. I'd end every living fossil if it means saving every mom in the future.

Now, here I am, about to turn 16 in a month, finally ready for the next step. And that's...

Acadia grabs the bone fragment, throws on her lab coat, moves toward the container, and starts reviewing its nearby documents.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

"Haiphong, Vietnam." Who else to give this cultural offering than the only Viet in a hundred square miles!

She YANKS the lid off the container. She looks inside with a mix of disdain and curiosity.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

I forgot how ugly Vietnamese horseshoe crabs are.

She pokes the creature with the bone and gets transports to the sailboat docked by her mom's secret island 8 years ago.

Acadia sentimentally touches the water. Horseshoe crabs swarm her hand. She slaps them away.

CÁT (V.O.)

(in Vietnamese; subtitled)

That's no way to treat the spirits of Fossil Island.

You must offer them the whole world. Offer them algae. Offer them mollusk shells. Offer them clams. Offer them fishes, CRABS! Offering everything will bring you...

Acadia holds up the real horseshoe crab, in a trance.

The horseshoe crab, dubbed KOOKY, TWITCHES, grabbing the bone from Acadia's hand and scarfing it down.

KOOKY

(Sweet familiar voice)

Ngon quááá!!!!

(Tasty!!!!)

Acadia cannot believe what she is hearing.

KOOKY (CONT'D)

I mean... *Woof?*

ACADIA

Ahhhhhhhhh!!!!!!

Acadia DROPS Kooky, who lands silently and SCUTTLES gracefully across the floor with a cat-like tread.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Security!

She dials a landline phone. The line is DEAD. She pulls the phone towards her— The cord is severed. Kooky sits nearby, the bone MUNCED in half. She flicks her tail, observing Acadia with curiosity.

KOOKY

This tastes nothing like a worm.

Kooky crawls UP THE WALL towards Acadia, a mirror of Cát's sass and a kitty. She corners Acadia.

ACADIA

I'm no worm either! Your voice is familiar.

KOOKY

We may be ugly, but we are smart.

Kooky cleans her shell with a leg, like a cat grooming.

ACADIA

We? Who you callin' ugly?! How are you talking?!

KOOKY

We had 445 million years to practice!

ACADIA

How old are you?!

KOOKY

My latest molt was 1000 days ago.

ACADIA

You're almost 16. My age...

KOOKY

I'm a molt away from maturity. I'm not ready to give up my childhood yet. Where are we? Is this Cát Bà??

ACADIA

How do you know Cát Bà...?

KOOKY

I was born there!

ACADIA

Which island?

KOOKY

Don't know. I've visited all 367. This must be the 368th, it smells like antiseptic and regret.

ACADIA

It's no island. This is America!

Kooky eyes the water tanks.

KOOKY

No wonder the horseshoe crabs here have such strange accents!

The Atlantic horseshoe crabs tap the tank glass aggressively.

HORSESHOE CRABS

She makes a killing out of us! A KILLING!

KOOKY

You make a killing out of what?!

ACADIA

(Panicked)

No killing here! That mid-Atlantic dialect can be so dramatic!

She grabs an evolutionary science book, SLAMS it open on the workstation to the horseshoe crab section.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

You're a tri-spine! There are three species in Asia! An Indo-Pacific horseshoe crab... *Tac-hi-*

KOOKY

Tachypleus gigas...

Acadia wells up remembering her mom say those tough words.

KOOKY (CONT'D)

(Squinting at the book)

Look inward, troglodyte!

ACADIA

Shut up, trilobite!

Acadia sees her reflection in the tank. The angry Atlantic horseshoe crabs swarm the glass.

HORSESHOE CRABS

Don't speak about your ancestors in that way!
This generation's stupid!

Acadia SCREAMS, drops the book,
and BOLTS out of the lab.

KOOKY

You're not stupid, you're just very, very ugly!

Kooky slowly follows behind,
munching the last bit of bone.

SCENE 2

SWING SET

As dusk approaches, Acadia grows exhausted. In the distance is a swing hanging from a tree by the lake. She sits on it.

In the lake, Kooky swims upside down towards Acadia. She gets on land and leaps onto the base of the swing set with surprising agility but remains upside down.

KOOKY

Little help?

Acadia sighs in frustration. She kicks Kooky right side up.

Kooky scuttles up and attaches herself to Acadia's leg, like a cat rubbing its face against a leg.

ACADIA

For a recently mature horseshoe crab, you seem elderly.

KOOKY

That's why we're called "living fossils."
Evolving never made us swing one way or the
other. But, my pals always said I was a kooky
horseshoe. I never quite fit in. I'm always
swinging from one nest to another. Do you have
a community?

ACADIA

I'm not in the mood.

KOOKY

Why not?

ACADIA

I experience mood swings.

KOOKY

Do you know what they are?

ACADIA

I don't... Yeah no, I do... Actually no yeah.
Well...

KOOKY

You're unwell.

ACADIA

These past years, it's been a sickness.

KOOKY

A mood sounds like a spell... Whoosh, you're
happy. Poof, you're sad. Zap, you're mad.
Swish, flabbergasted. But the good news is...
It'll always swing back to happy!

Kooky repeats it like a song.

ACADIA

But the good news is, it'll always swing back
to happy! Though one time, I stayed sad for
what seemed like forever. No one is here to
push my swing.

Kooky crawls onto Acadia's back,
nudging her head gently with her
shell. They push her literally and
encouragingly.

KOOKY

I have ten legs. They're not great at pushing
physical things, but they're here to push your
spirit.

ACADIA & KOOKY

Mood sounds like a spell! Whoosh, you're happy!
Poof, you're sad! Zap, you're mad! Swish,
flabbergasted! But the good news is, it'll
always swing back to happy!

KOOKY

Swing one way or the other!
You're perfect one way or another!

ACADIA

I hereby declare you... KOOKY...

KOOKY

That's sweet!

ACADIA

Like all cookies! Except raisins. Now, Kooky...

KOOKY

Yes, caddie?

ACADIA

Whoa.

KOOKY

What?

ACADIA

No one calls me... well... um.

KOOKY

I call all my friends that. I'm an addict of
golf, okay?

ACADIA

Golf's the national sport of retirement homes.
You are a living fossil.

KOOKY

(Mockingly)

Pffffff... You are a living fossil.

ACADIA

Now's a perfect time to swing by Fossil
Island...

KOOKY

Perfect! Let's swim there.

ACADIA

Too far. We need to get to a seaport. Dad once
took me to Port Newark. That's our best option.

KOOKY

Walk us there.

ACADIA

It's not walking distance. We need a ride. We have to steal the research drone.

KOOKY

Stealing is bad.

ACADIA

When did your species have morals?

KOOKY

(Rapidly)

Just cause you don't understand our quiet ways doesn't mean we don't feel things deeply, it means we've had more time to think about them.

ACADIA

445 billion-

KOOKY

Million! We're not that old!

ACADIA

Not too old to fly.

KOOKY

But wings are primitive!

On the scrim, a world map or globe pops up. A line traces from Maine to northern Vietnam.

SCENE 3

HANOI

In the early morning, Acadia enters with Kooky on her shoulder. The city of Hanoi sprawls out before them. Land development has taken its toll with endless concrete. High-rises cast shadows over bustling markets. Vendors push carts overflowing with goods.

KOOKY

(Singing to David Bowie's *Changes*)

CH-CH-CH-CHANGES!

ACADIA

LEARN TO FACE THE STRANGE...

KOOKY

CURRENTS!

ACADIA

A mid David Bowie song. Not his best.

KOOKY

Well, I told ya to pack a charging adaptor. Now ya phone's dead.

ACADIA

It's not everyday one listens to music on her portable horseshoe crab.

KOOKY

How was this portable horseshoe crab allowed to fly?

ACADIA

DOGE dismantled TSA.

KOOKY

DOGE? TSA? Are those parasites?

ACADIA

You can say that. Airport security's a thing of the past. And we're lucky our drone flew.

KOOKY

Those giant birds are stubborn things...

ACADIA

I'd like to speak to any bird right about now. I have no idea where we are.

KOOKY

Let me feel the soil, Cadi.

Acadia sets Kooky on the ground.

Acadia sets Kooky on her shoulder.
She opens a map from the pamphlet.
Viet money and a US type charger
fall out.

KOOKY (CONT'D)

It tracks.

ACADIA

It / tracks?

KOOKY

/ Boots, netting, hand trucks, fishiness. We've arrived in Haiphong!

ACADIA

Duh. There's signs.

KOOKY

My eyes are not evolved to read.

ACADIA

Welp, you can see that it ain't as green... as I remembered it to be.

KOOKY

Land development.

ACADIA

It hasn't made this map easier to read...

KOOKY

How about ya get around like me through intuition?

ACADIA

I'll just ask for directions... Get to know the locals!

KOOKY

The locals son locos.

ACADIA

America did wonders to you.

Acadia goes to a merchant's booth.
The merchant remains unseen.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Hi. You know how to get to Haiphong from here?

CHOP CHOP. Horseshoe crab guts are
thrown out into the open.

KOOKY

Savages! Sisters and brothers and in-between,
hold the rubber and salty aftertaste! Wishing
you and everyone here food poisoning!

ACADIA

Intuition it is...

Acadia faces the path made from
the horseshoe crabs' remains.

The path leads to a scooter.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

Saddle up! Put on your shoes! Let's go to Haiphong in style!

Kooky shields Acadia's head.

KOOKY

Don't forget to wear a helmet.

Acadia drives the scooter on the highway. They weave past traffic.

KOOKY (CONT'D)

Those legs you call wheels? Faster than my 10 legs.

ACADIA

My two legs are faster than you.

KOOKY

Bet you're not a better swimmer.

ACADIA

How so?

KOOKY

To navigate its currents, we must change our direction, not just our location. We adapt to the flow. We don't fight the tide.

ACADIA

So advice from a crustacean is: be flexible?

KOOKY

More like, embrace the chaos. Hermit crabs are always moving to new shells. They're never satisfied.

ACADIA

I know hermits... Um...

KOOKY

Change isn't about being different. Change is about finding the right fit for who you're meant to be, even if it means a bumpy ride.

ACADIA

I guess my lab back in Maine was a pretty tight shell, wasn't it?

KOOKY

It was... probably for the other horseshoe crabs too.

ACADIA

They smelled like antiseptic and regret.

KOOKY

Phenomenal.

ACADIA

Pho... Before we set sail, I gotta take you to this pho place. Mom made my birthday special there.

They park by a restaurant and find a table.

SCENE 4

PHO RESTAURANT IN HAIPHONG, VIETNAM

This restaurant is where Acadia used to go to with her mom on her birthdays. Kooky and Acadia sit at a table opposite of each other. Acadia's bowl of PHO is untouched. Empty plates of mollusk shells are stacked on Kooky's side.

The placemats are blank canvas.

KOOKY

Take me to a place where you don't eat the food. Real encouraging.

ACADIA

I still can't believe this is the same place. It smells the same, but different. Cleaner?

KOOKY

Change isn't always about scent, Cadi. Sometimes it's about what you don't see anymore.

ACADIA

The placemats are different. No more zodiacs. Mom used to take a picture of me every year with the animal of my birth year, starting from my first birthday.

KOOKY

And every year you didn't eat your pho. You're a creature of habit.

ACADIA

I was a kid. You've been eating all the mollusk shells, though.

KOOKY

They're not just food. They're empty homes. A home isn't just wood or a shell, but a place where you can become who you're meant to be.

ACADIA

That's my mom's tale.

KOOKY

And how does it end?

ACADIA

It ended with me becoming biochemist who dissects your kind. I didn't become who I was meant to be. I destroyed their homes.

Kooky crawls up to Acadia's shoulder.

KOOKY

The past is a place we visit, not where we live. Your mom came here on your birthday to remind you of your roots, of the source of where you come from. Not to chain you to it.

ACADIA

You know so much about mom- So my past... it's not a cage?

KOOKY

It's a foundation. You built a lab on yours. Now it's time to decide what you'll build next.

Acadia picks up the chopsticks.
She finally eats something.

ACADIA

Right. I need my strength.

Acadia switches out the chopsticks for paddles.

The table turns into a rowboat.

SCENE 5

THE ROWBOAT IN THE SEA

With Kooky on her shoulder, Acadia rows the boat into the fog.

ACADIA

Where to, Captain Kooky?

KOOKY

Just keep going straight, Cadi. I'll tell you when to turn. I know this area better than myself.

ACADIA

That's what my mom said. You're a fraction of her size. How do you know this place so well?

KOOKY

I'm a creature of habit, unlike you messy humans. I grew up exploring all 367 islands. I know this route like the back of my shell.

ACADIA

All of them? Whatev-

KOOKY

Yep. And the best part? There's a shortcut right up ahead. A straight shot to Fossil Island. It'll save us.

ACADIA

Phone, is this a shortcut?

PHONE (V.O.)

(in Vietnamese)

Once again, no signal.

KOOKY

Signal left. You're right where you belong.

The sailboat approaches the whirlpool once again.

The boat bobs precariously near the edge of the vortex. The wind whistles. Acadia grips the edge of the boat, peering into the swirling water. Kooky sits on her shoulder, tail flicking.

ACADIA

This is insane, Kooky! We can't go that way! It's a... kinetic clash!

KOOKY

It's a shortcut, Cadi.

ACADIA

It's where mom and me cut off...

KOOKY

It's the only way to your ancestral island. And your lesson in humility.

ACADIA

Humility? I'm a biochemist! I graduated college at 10! I understand shortcuts real well!

KOOKY

You've treated my kind unwell... as specimens, not souls! You've made a killing out of us. Now, feel our power.

ACADIA

So... you do know where we're going! You tricked me!

KOOKY

Of course. A multi-million-year-old creature better have a decent sense of direction.

ACADIA

I did what I had to do! It was for medicine, to save people! My mom would've-

KOOKY

And our blood heals, yes. But you took without asking, without respect. You thought we had no bones, no spirit. Now look.

Acadia stares into the whirlpool, mesmerized by the blue light swirling from the seafloor. It reminds her of the color of the blood she harvested.

CÁT (V.O.)

The world has sharp teeth. We're armored for a reason, little one.

ACADIA

Bite me... I called you a trilobite. I was wrong. I was so arrogant. I didn't think you felt things.

KOOKY

Bite me!

ACADIA

I see that now. All those shells in the lab... they were homes. And I... I destroyed them. I'm sorry, Kooky. I'm so sorry.

Acadia places a hand on Kooky's shell, the first time she's touched her with genuine affection.

ACADIA (CONT'D)

So, how do we do this?

KOOKY

You let go of what you think you know. We're going to be okay. No souls lost on my watch.

ACADIA

Right. *Nho nguon*. When drinking water, remember the source.

Acadia tightens her grip on Kooky, feeling fear and resolve. She is ready. Kooky nudges her, and they prepare for the plunge.

KOOKY

Ready to meet your ancestors?

Acadia and Kooky jump, swallowed by the swirling depths.

Black out.

SCENE 6

FOSSIL ISLAND

Under the sunlight, Acadia lies face up and unconscious on the sand. Kooky rests on her chest.

ACADIA

I feel like a fossil...

KOOKY

This is what it feels like to live.

Acadia turns to see the familiar horseshoe-shaped cliffside. They are back! She stands up and places Kooky on her shoulder. They enter the forest. They hike through, uncover trails, and climb boulders.

They soon reach a shrine.
Horseshoe crab shells are
uniformly positioned. They each
have red markings on them.

ACADIA

I ain't feeling it with the dead. Undead?

KOOKY

They're molted shells from many generations of
horseshoe crabs.

ACADIA

But those markings are human blood... from many
generations.

KOOKY

We've held your generations' blood for safe
keeping.

ACADIA

That's messed up.

KOOKY

There are lots of messed things these ten legs
can do.

ACADIA

I don't wanna know...

KOOKY

Well *scientist*, what's messed up is that you
stash our blue blood.

ACADIA

Touché.

KOOKY

Put me in, kid.

Acadia places Kooky in the little
pond. The pond swirls.

Kooky is now a hat on Cát's head
when she transforms into her.
Dressed in the same veil of a
horseshoe crab, Cát sees Acadia.
They share a smile. A connection.
They hold hands.

CÁT

Happy birthday, Acadia. You've made it just in
time.

ACADIA

Me ("Mom")... I've missed you. FIRST THINGS
FIRST. It's time to tell me what's going on.

CÁT

For generations, our ancestors lived in harmony
with these living fossils. On their last molt
and our 15th cycle, we gift them our blood.
But, you're the first in the family to draw
theirs.

ACADIA

Teens need to experiment...

With her left hand, Cát takes
KOOKY's molt off her head.

CÁT & KOOKY

My last molt.

Cát releases her right-hand grip
from Acadia. Acadia's hand is now
cut there, but it is painless. She
places her bloody hand on Kooky's
last molt, leaving her mark. She
sets Kooky's molt in an open spot
alongside the other generations'
molts.

CÁT

Look at us, we haven't changed at all, have we?
Don't ever change how you see the world. We
need to dress for the occasion!

Acadia walks away. Cát runs and
throws horseshoe crab-esque
clothes on Acadia, so that they
are matching.

ACADIA

You haven't changed either, Mom.

CÁT

I'll stay by your side, loving you, please
never change.

ACADIA

It's tough getting older, isn't it? Wrinkles
appear, memories fade, there's so much stress.
Time just keeps taking its toll.

The spirits of Acadia, Cát, and
even Kooky's ancestors manifest
from the shrine.

CÁT
when you're older, your heart stays young!

ACADIA
We're living fossils?

CÁT (CONT'D)
We're living fossils...

Acadia and Cát embrace.

ACADIA (CONT'D)
And you never will change... You've never
strayed from me, Mom. You never changed.

ACADIA & CÁT
I'll stay by your side, loving you, let's never
change!

Acadia and Cát dive off the cliff
and into the sea. They transform
into horseshoe crabs and swim off,
becoming shadows in the fog.

END OF PLAY